Warriors make quick work of Bullets / Details, B-1

WEATHER: Chance of showers. High 63, low 49. Details, A-14.

WEDNESDAY: March 16, 1994

The Oakland Tribune.

All-America City

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Death-penalty foes charge racial bias

Study shows federal prosecution targets minorities

By Meredith K. Wadman
WASHINGTON BUREAU

WASHINGTON — Attorney General Janet Reno has authorized 10 federal death penalty prosecutions in the year since she took office — every one of them against an African American.

Of the 37 defendants put on trial for their lives since 1988 under the one federal law that allows the death penalty, 33 are members of minority groups. The total includes 29 blacks, four Hispanics and four whites.

In contrast, three-fourths of the defendants convicted under the 1988 law, the Anti-Drug Abuse Act, are white. There have been no executions under the law, which allows the death penalty for certain drug-related murders.

The Justice Department has not responded to an October request from a House Judiciary subcommittee for an explanation about the dramatic racial disparities.

These were among the facts in a new report that shows "extreme racial inequities in federal death-penalty prosecution," said Rep. Don Edwards, D-San Jose, the chairman of the civil and constitutional rights subcommittee of the House Judiciary Committee. He released the report Tuesday.

"Racial Disparities in Federal Death

Please see **Penalty,** page A-7

Canseco had suicidal thoughts

Texas Rangers slugger Jose Canseco told a columnist that he considered committing suicide over the downfall of his personal and professional life. He never tried to kill himself, seeking counseling instead.

Details on page B-1

State spares county of rapist

Schoolgirl slain

RON RIESTERER — Staff

San Pablo police talk to residents near Downer Elementary School, where 15-year-old Cecilia Rios was found dead. School was closed for the day after the discovery so police could investigate the area.

Families live in fear in tough neighborhood

By Diana M. Williams
STAFF WRITER

SAN PABLO — Agonizing screams of a mother discovering her murdered daughter's body echoed through a schoolyard and jolted neighbors awake early Tuesday.

"It was a horrible screech, like someone in terrible pain," said Verna Kalberer, whose home faces the elementary school where a 15-year-old's body was discovered by her parents at 6:30 a.m.

Police are saying little about the killing, including how, where or exactly when the girl was killed. But friends and neighbors identified her as Cecilia Rios, a popular Richmond High School student who lived with her family in a working-class neighborhood. It's an area where rival gangs fight in broad daylight, but police would not comment on whether the girl's death was gang-related.

Cecilia Rios

The murder scene at Edward M. Downer Elementary School was cordoned off at about 7 a.m. by police. Teachers hung hastily lettered signs in both Spanish and English, saying the school was closed for the day.

The unexpected news sent hundreds of parents scrambling to find places to put their children. Many students were taken in by neighbors and relatives, said Downer Principal Catherine Syversen. Others went to nearby schools.

By noon, the scene was calm. Students and residents stood behind yellow police tape, watching detectives wave metal detectors over the schoolyard

—Please see **Slain** page A-7

RON RIESTERER — Staff

Neighbors of Cecilia Rios gather in disbelief near the school.

Outcry alters decision on Carter's parole

By Sam Delson
SACRAMENTO BUREAU

SACRAMENTO — Facing a storm of protest from angry East Bay residents, a state official said Tuesday that serial rapist Melvin Carter will not be paroled to Alameda County.

"Mr. Carter is not coming to Alameda County," said Craig Brown, undersecretary of the California Youth and Adult Correctional Agency. "If I lived in that county and thought he was headed there, I'd be upset too."

➤ **A look at where other criminals have been paroled/A-9**

Carter, the former Pleasanton resident who has admitted to raping 100 women near college campuses, had been scheduled to be released to Hayward after serving 12 years of a 25-year sentence. But public outrage led Gov. Pete Wilson to announce Monday that he would not be placed in Hayward or any other urban center near a college.

State law requires that parolees be released in the county where they were convicted unless the release is found to be not "in the best interests of the public and the parolee" or it would place the parolee close to a victim of his or her crime.

Wilson said Carter, who was

Please see **Parole,** page A-7

Bad news on base closings: no money

By Kathleen Kirkwood
STAFF WRITER

ALAMEDA — At least three closing Bay Area bases have reportedly received the bad news and the even-worse news: only a fraction of closure money will reach their shores this year and it won't get better in 1995.

In Alameda, the Naval Air Station won't see any of a requested $22.1 million in closure funds, according to a base spokeswoman.

And at the Naval Aviation Depot, only $2.3 million will be available — out of a total $14.4 million requested, sources said.

At Mare Island Naval Shipyard in Vallejo, $47.1 million will be available for closure this year, according to Rep. George Miller, D-Martinez, who testified Tuesday before a House subcommittee on military construction.

See **Bases,** page A-7

Federal officials claim OHA wasted $1.4 million

By Craig Staats
STAFF WRITER

OAKLAND — Through deliberate delays and poor judgment, the Oakland Housing Authority wasted nearly $1.4 million during a $6.2 million rehabilitation of a 96-unit East Oakland housing project, according to a new federal audit.

A U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development memorandum, dated Feb. 17, claims the housing authority intentionally delayed work at the Tassafaronga Village apartment complex, failed to pursue a timely waiver of handicapped accessibility requirements and prematurely relocated tenants to save on maintenance costs.

In its stinging memo, HUD said OHA's actions resulted in $1.39 million in additional costs — nearly $1 million in increased vandalism and $397,312 due to construction delays.

OHA spokeswoman Lily Toney said the housing authority has "never, ever seen this report" and would respond to the

Please see **HUD,** page A-7

Good morning . . .

More home owners

Fannie Mae program to help 10 million low- and moderate-income families buy houses. **[C-1]**

Read, then recycle
We use recycled paper

Elevated freeways gain approval

BCDC staff bucks environmentalists wishes in planning shoreline freeways. **[A-9]**

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Why that candy can be irresistible

■ Scientists say a gene might give some people a sweeth tooth

By Cecily Burt
STAFF WRITER

SAN FRANCISCO — Ever wonder why some people are satisfied after eating one or two teensy bites of a chocolate torte while you're left craving the whole pie?

New evidence suggests that a "sweet-tooth" gene — the same gene that's linked to addictive behaviors such as alcoholism, tobacco or drug abuse — may be responsible for some folks' uncontrollable food cravings.

Ernest Noble, a doctor at the UCLA School of Medicine, has pioneered previous studies on genetics and substance abuse. His brother Rudolf Nobel, director of the Cathedral Hill Obesity Clinic in San Francisco, began to wonder if the gene could be responsible for food abuse, as well.

The study, published in the current issue of the International Journal of Eating Disorders, found that more than half of the 73 overweight subjects at an obesity clinic in San Francisco have a specific genetic makeup that makes them crave foods loaded in carbohydrates — especially sweets.

"I was wondering if we have carbohoics — people who are addicted to food — so I screened 73 patients," said Rudolf Nobel. "Lo and behold, 64 percent had this particular molecular genetic pattern."

People with the "sweet-tooth" gene lack dopamine receptors in the brain and must keep eating to feel sated, Noble said. For them, eating certain types of food can produce sensations of euphoria or pleasure, similar to the effect of drugs or alcohol.

And those who crave carbohydrates have a 3 to 1 propensity for being a carboholic, the researchers found.

But don't jump off the diet treadmill just yet, Noble warned.

"Ideally, it would be nice to develop a chemical or drug to go into the brain and push more dopamine out," he said. "But science marches slowly. I'd guess we'll have something in maybe a decade."

NICK LAMMERS — Staff

Walt Medeiros, 42, of Oakland enjoys a Jersey Special at Fenton's.